

Sabretache of the 8th Hussars
A distinctive leather satchel carried by cavalrymen, the sabretache hung from the sabre belt on the left flank of the horse. Originally holding writing and sketching materials, by Napoleonic times it was largely decorative.

It is not surprising, then, that first lancers in the Napoleonic cavalry were Poles. In 1811 a number of dragoon regiments were converted into lancers, as the usefulness of a weapon around 3m (10ft) long was becoming increasingly apparent. The lancers were potentially effective against infantry squares – immune to all other forms of cavalry attack – since their lances outreached the musket and bayonet. Lancers were also great skirmishers on the battlefield, marauding at will. In a cavalry mêlée, however, their long weapon was an unwieldy encumbrance and no match for the sabre. To cope with this defect, not all the men in lancer regiments were armed with lances. Each group of riders that carried lances was supported by a number of comrades with sabres drawn.

The dragoons were numerically the largest element of the French cavalry. As they were armed with muskets and had originally been soldiers who rode to battle but fought on foot, Napoleon was tempted to use them in battle as infantry. They proved unsatisfactory in that role, however, not possessing the disciplined steadiness of true foot soldiers. At the same time, the distraction of infantry training tended to reduce their effectiveness in the saddle. Still, in the early battles of the Napoleonic Wars the dragoons frequently distinguished themselves fighting alongside the cuirassiers as a kind of ancillary semi-heavy cavalry. From 1807 they served chiefly in the Peninsular War in Spain. As well as fighting Wellington's army on many occasions, they were immersed in the cruel, dirty war of ambushes and reprisals against Spanish guerrilla fighters.

CAVALRY IN ACTION

The French cavalry won its reputation as a battle-winning force early on in the Napoleonic Wars. At Marengo in 1800, a charge by some 400 troopers commanded by General François Etienne Kellerman plunged into the flank of an Austrian infantry and cavalry column 6,000-strong, driving them from the field in panic and confusion at a moment when the French had been facing almost certain defeat. The Napoleonic cavalry reached its peak of effectiveness, however, in the period 1805 to 1812. Well mounted, thoroughly trained, decked out in splendid uniforms, and utterly self-confident, they were an elite that proved its worth in battle after battle. They made a notable contribution to the victories at Ulm and Austerlitz in 1805, but their most spectacular performance was probably against the Russians at Eylau in February 1807. At a desperate moment in the battle, Murat led the 10,000-strong cavalry reserve in a charge that swept through the Russian infantry, then reformed and charged through them a second time to regain the French lines.

Napoleon's invasion of Russia in 1812, however, brought catastrophe. Even at the start of the campaign, the lack of adequate forage for the massive cavalry force – the cavalry reserve alone was 40,000 strong – meant that many of the horses began to starve. "One saw their great emaciated bodies dragging themselves along," an eyewitness commented. "Every minute one would quiver and fall on its rider, who abandoned it." The Russian Cossacks proved superior to the French hussars and cuirassiers

> YOU PERCEIVED IN THE DISTANCE WHAT APPEARED TO BE AN OVERWHELMING, LONG MOVING LINE ... ON CAME THE MOUNTED HOST ... WHILE THE VERY EARTH SEEMED TO VIBRATE BENEATH THEIR THUNDERING TRAMP.
>
> **BRITISH INFANTRYMAN** DESCRIBING THE FRENCH CAVALRY CHARGE AT WATERLOO

The cuirassiers at Austerlitz
Napoleon considered Austerlitz his finest victory. He skilfully manoeuvred his forces around the battlefield to gain local numerical superiority and then ordered attacks at crucial points and decisive moments. Here the cuirassiers wait their turn to charge.

